

Transportation Solutions Operating Benchmark

Two-page source brief | Four structurally distinct archetypes | Analysis date: July 18, 2026

SUBVERTICAL THESIS

Transportation Solutions is not a single benchmark. The report separates railcar leasing, locomotive leasing, airport ground-support-equipment (GSE) full-service leasing, and outsourced yard logistics because asset life, service intensity, contract structure, utilization and capital recovery differ structurally. Rail lessors earn high margins on scarce, long-lived assets but reinvest materially and recover capital over many years. Airport GSE combines rental with maintenance, spare fleets and airport-specific deployment, lowering margins and conversion. Lazer is labor-led outsourced operations, not an asset lessor: margins are lower, sustaining capex and payback are much lighter, and service-capacity utilization dominates. Only the mission-critical, predominantly B2B customer profile carries cleanly across all four.

METRIC	BENCHMARK RANGE	WHY THE ASSERTION MAKES SENSE	STRONGEST SUPPORT / CAVEAT
Revenue growth	Railcar 1% / 4% / 7%; Loco 3% / 6% / 10%; GSE 5% / 8% / 12%; Yard 4% / 7% / 11%.	Railcar growth is price, fleet additions and utilization; locomotives add modernization demand. GSE gains from outsourcing and electrification. Yard growth is new sites and cross-sell.	VTG reported strong tank-wagon but weaker intermodal utilization; Akiem has placed major orders and completed a EUR1.52 billion green refinancing; Air Rail and TCR disclosed expanding fleets; Lazer serves 550+ sites. Confidence: Medium; normalized and triangulated, with private-company segment disclosure limiting precision.
EBITDA margin	Railcar 52% / 58% / 65%; Loco 55% / 62% / 70%; GSE 24% / 30% / 36% (observed 20%-38%); Yard 10% / 14% / 18%.	Rail earns high lease spreads, tempered by maintenance and off-lease drag. GSE bears technician and workshop cost. Yard payroll and shift efficiency cap margins.	Akiem's official 2021 transaction data showed roughly EUR150 million EBITDA on EUR220 million revenue. TCR runs 100+ workshops and about 1,000 technicians. Lazer reports 5,000 employees and 9 million annual service hours. Confidence: Medium; Air Rail's 20% / 27% / 33% range is Low due to mixed, private reporting.
Maintenance capex / revenue	Railcar 14% / 18% / 24%; Loco 12% / 18% / 25%; GSE 10% / 14% / 18%; Yard 2% / 4% / 7%.	Wagons need overhaul and replacement; locomotives add ERTMS and compliance work. GSE needs refurbishment and batteries. Yard sustains tractors and tech only.	VTG spent EUR536 million on fixed assets in 2024, mainly new wagons and fleet maintenance. Akiem is upgrading about 250 locomotives for ERTMS. Air Rail and TCR explicitly provide full lifecycle maintenance and refurbishment. Confidence: Medium overall; exact private-company gross sustaining spend is the report's lowest-confidence area.
Post-maintenance capex conversion	Railcar 54% / 69% / 78%; Loco 55% / 71% / 83%; GSE 40% / 55% / 67% (observed 35%-69%); Yard 55% / 71% / 84%.	The measure is (EBITDA minus maintenance capex) / EBITDA, not full free cash flow. Rail and GSE margins are high, but sustaining fleet spend absorbs cash; Lazer's lower margin is offset by a much lighter physical-capital burden.	Ranges are calculated directly from each archetype's normalized EBITDA and maintenance-capex assumptions and exclude interest, taxes, working capital, lease principal and growth capex. Confidence: Medium; derived, with sensitivity to the growth-versus-sustaining capex split.
Initial contract tenor	Railcar 2 / 4 / 7 years; Loco 5 / 7 / 10; GSE 3 / 5 / 7; Yard 1 / 3 / 5.	High unit value and approvals require longer locomotive terms. Wagon and GSE packages are medium term. Yard mobilization needs less legal duration than large assets.	VTG materials describe medium-to-long-term wagon hire; Akiem supports rolling stock through handback; TCR is described as having long-term contractual relationships. Lazer is embedded operationally but replaceable at rebid. Confidence: Medium; largely inferred because weighted-average contract terms are not publicly disclosed.
Effective customer tenure	Railcar 6 / 9 / 12 years; Loco 8 / 12 / 15; GSE 6 / 9 / 13 (observed 5-14); Yard 4 / 7 / 10.	Customer life outlasts one asset or site contract. Industrial wagon pools, approved locomotive fleets, multi-airport placements and deeply integrated yard staffing are resized, renewed or refreshed without changing provider.	The report cites fleet integration in industrial flows, Akiem's framework and lifecycle support, TCR's long-term relationships, and Lazer customer testimony about embedded operating performance. Confidence: Medium; tenure is inferred from integration, not disclosed churn cohorts.
Utilization exposure	Railcar Moderate / Moderate / High; Loco Moderate / Moderate / High; GSE Moderate / Moderate-to-High / High; Yard High / High / High.	Rail depends on paid deployment and redeployment; locomotive downtime is concentrated. GSE adds ramp use and spare fleets. Yard depends on productive labor hours.	VTG's intermodal utilization weakened while tank wagons stayed high. TCR discusses idle-fleet waste and telematics right-sizing. Lazer's 9 million annual service hours make service-capacity utilization the decisive KPI. Confidence: Medium for asset models; High for Lazer's classification.
New-unit / customer payback	Railcar 7 / 9 / 12 years; Loco 8 / 10 / 13; GSE 4 / 5.5 / 7.5; Yard 0.8 / 1.5 / 2.5.	Rail needs multiple placements and residual value. GSE is cheaper but service-heavy. Yard launch spend is mainly recruiting, training, limited equipment and tech.	All ranges are triangulated from fully burdened investment and unit- or site-level cash contribution after direct cost and a maintenance reserve; none uses revenue payback alone. Confidence: Medium; Air Rail's company-specific payback is Low confidence because segment financials are thin.
B2B versus B2C	Railcar, Loco, GSE and Yard: predominantly B2B; Loco includes public-authority exposure.	Customers buy capital relief, uptime, compliance and outsourcing. Contracts sit with operators, authorities, airports, handlers, industrial firms and 3PLs.	Each company's official customer description is institutional; the report found no economically relevant direct B2C revenue stream in the benchmarked segments. Confidence: High.

HOW TO READ THE UNIVERSE

Five businesses map to four models: VTG is the railcar reference; Akiem is a mixed leasing-plus-maintenance locomotive platform; TCR is the core airport-GSE reference and Air Rail a smaller mixed airport/rail reference; Lazer is a separate outsourced-operations archetype. The economic unit shifts from one earning wagon or locomotive, to a GSE station package, to a yard-site contract and service hour.

VTG

What it does. Leases and manages European freight wagons for industrial shippers and rail operators.

Economic model. Unit: earning wagon; revenue: recurring lease plus services. Customers avoid capital and secure compliant, cargo-specific capacity. VTG maintains and redeploys fleets; integration retains customers, while lane loss and intermodal weakness create churn. Long life and residuals offset heavy sustaining work.

Evidence bridge. 2024: EUR405m operating cash flow and EUR536m fixed-asset investment, mainly new wagons and maintenance; tank utilization stayed high while intermodal softened.

Akiem

What it does. Leases and maintains locomotives and some passenger rolling stock across Europe.

Economic model. Unit: locomotive under lease/full service. Operators outsource scarce, compliant traction. Akiem runs workshops, overhauls and upgrades; approvals and uptime support retention, while concession loss or technical mismatch cause churn. Long contracts, residuals and repeat placements fund heavy capital needs.

Evidence bridge. 2021: 600+ locomotives, 46 passenger trains, about EUR220m revenue and EUR150m EBITDA. A EUR1.52bn 2026 refinancing supports growth; about 250 locomotives are receiving ERTMS.

Air Rail

What it does. AIR RAIL, S.L. leases, maintains and refurbishes airport GSE; it also has rail activities.

Economic model. Unit: deployed GSE/station package. Rental, maintenance, parts and resale solve airline/handler capex and uptime needs. Airport service embeds relationships; rebids and transfer friction cause churn. Fleets, batteries and charging drive capital needs.

Evidence bridge. IFM owns 75%. March 2026: 4,700+ units, about 60 airports, eight countries and 68% of motorized units electric. Identity is High confidence; segment metrics are lower confidence.

TCR

What it does. Rents, maintains, refurbishes and electrifies GSE for airlines, handlers and airports.

Economic model. Unit: GSE/airport fleet package. Full-service rent and lifecycle services solve turnaround uptime and capital needs. Workshops, technicians and spares embed TCR; handler rebids drive churn. Scale aids utilization but requires renewal and reserve fleet.

Evidence bridge. 44,000+ assets, 100+ workshops, 1,800+ employees, 24 countries and 200+ airports. GIP's March 2026 acquisition agreement was expected to close in Q3.

Lazer Logistics

What it does. Runs warehouse and industrial yards using drivers, equipment, processes and technology.

Economic model. Unit: site contract/service hour. Recurring site and labor revenue solves trailer-flow bottlenecks. Lazer staffs and supervises yards; integration supports retention, while rebids, closures and volume loss cause churn. Labor utilization dominates limited equipment capital.

Evidence bridge. EQT reports 550+ sites, 5,000 employees, 6,000 fleet assets and 9m annual service hours. Lazer is outsourced operations, not an asset-leasing benchmark.

KEY DILIGENCE QUESTIONS

Do not blend the four archetypes: the asset-owner versus labor-operator distinction drives margins, capex, utilization and payback. | Private-company maintenance capex is the weakest metric; obtain gross replacement, refurbishment, battery/electrification and growth-fleet splits. | Measure paid utilization by asset family, off-lease days and redeployment cost rather than relying on headline fleet counts. | Separate legal term from customer life and isolate airport-, lane- or site-level churn from whole-account retention. | Air Rail's legal identity is resolved, but its airport GSE segment remains mixed with rail activities; TCR's ownership was signed but not closed at the analysis date.